NAVAL WARFARE IN ASIA



Samurai warriors at sea
Samurai sailed out on fast, light boats to harass the invasion fleets of Kublai Khan's Mongols. Two attempts to invade Japan from China failed, the second in 1281 when the invasion fleet was destroyed by a typhoon.

THE DEVELOPMENT OF NAVAL WARFARE in East Asia was in some ways similar to that of Europe. At the time of the Roman Empire, Chinese warships fought using the tactics of ramming or grappling and boarding just as fleets did in the Mediterranean. The Chinese even had an equivalent to the corvus, the Romans' boarding bridge. Naval warfare in Japan, where samurai contested land battles on water fought with bows and swords, at times resembled the battles fought between seaborne medieval European knights and archers. Yet Asian navies developed a distinctive range of ships, including large numbers of vessels with paddlewheels, a form of propulsion that did not catch on in Europe until the steam era. The Chinese in particular were at the cutting edge of technology, using gunpowder, crossbows, and the compass earlier than Europeans, and by the 15th century building the world's largest sailing ships.

MASSIVE BATTLES

There is record of naval battles in China dating back to around 400 BCE, but land warfare was understandably the major preoccupation of the Chinese emperors, given their country's barely defensible western frontier. Battles on rivers and lakes usually accompanied land operations. Japan and Korea also developed naval forces early on. The Koreans largely outfought the Chinese in the Yellow Sea during the wars between the Korean Goguryeo and Chinese Sui dynasties from 598 to 614. The Chinese navy was more successful against Japan in the Baekje War, fought in Korea in 663. Under the Tang Dynasty (618–907) Chinese influence was extended around southeast Asia into the Indian Ocean and across to the east coast of Africa. This brought the Chinese into contact with Arab sailors and with Indian fleets such as that of the southern Indian Chola dynasty in the 11th century. By the time the Song dynasty founded China's first permanent navy in 1132, southern China almost certainly had the world's largest concentration of naval forces. The Song fought massive naval battles against Jurchen Jin and Mongol Yuan assailants from the north. After the Yuan triumphed over the Song under Kublai Khan in the 1270s, Chinese naval power was asserted from the Indian Ocean to Japan—although Yuan attempts at a seaborne invasion of Japan failed. The Japanese, meanwhile, were feared as pirates raiding the coasts of the Asian mainland. They also undertook major naval battles during the civil conflict known as the Gempei Wars, fought in the 12th century, when the movement of troops around Japan's Inland Sea became strategically crucial. A naval victory at Dan-no-Ura ensured that the Minamoto clan would take power in Japan as shoguns in 1185.

Legends of the Three Kingdoms
Three leaders competing for the fragmented Han Empire fought a decisive river battle at Red Cliffs in 208 CE. This illustration shows legendary events from the period, including "borrowing" arrows by sailing boats manned with straw scarecrows past the enemy's camp.



SHIPS AND WEAPONRY

The Chinese developed a range of warship types with different tactical roles. These included large multi-deck war junks and "tower ships" with portholes through which crossbows could be fired and lances thrust, and often carrying varieties of catapult. Smaller vessels included "covered swoopers," fast assault ships covered with thick hides to protect against missiles and incendiary devices, which were designed for aggressive "swoops" on the enemy. "Flying barques" were fast moving galleys with more oarsmen than usual and a smaller